

Major Reflection: Part 2

PLEASE READ THROUGH THIS INFORMATION CAREFULLY BEFORE PROCEEDING WITH YOUR REFLECTION.

For each of the questions below, take some time to reflect on the key concepts from this course that have been particularly helpful and meaningful. You may find it helpful to review the course modules and previous assignments as each question asks you to include references to specific content addressed in this course. If you were not employed this term, consider experiences you may have had in other work or academic terms, or via extracurricular activities (i.e., Working in a group, presentations, volunteering positions, personal experience, etc.).

Question 1

Select one of the prompts below and address it in detail, drawing from your learning and experiences this term.

Use the DEAL Model of Reflection to respond to your chosen prompt. Information on how to use the DEAL model to reflect can be found on the "How to Write a D.E.A.L. Reflection" page located in the Assignment section of Learn and linked to from the Major Reflective Report assignment page.

Prompt A

A: Describe how some aspect of your work experience this term helped you understand a PD9 concept, skill/technique, or tool better.

Sometimes we learn things in a course but do not fully understand them until we have an unplanned but related real-life experience. For example, maybe you dealt with someone who had an "if-it's-not-illegal-it's-ok" attitude, or you were involved in an ethical dispute that required unwavering commitment to your principles or finding a middle ground for a compromise. Perhaps you experienced pitfalls of moral hazard where you now recognize that your behaviour changed because of being shielded from consequences, or you found yourself (or witnessed others) playing the ultimatum game. Or perhaps a supervisor (or professor, or friend, or family member) shared stories about their own positive or negative experiences related to aspects of ethical decision making.

1. **Describe:** Describe the concept, skill/technique, or tool, and describe the experience in detail (who, what, where, when).
2. **Examine:** Explain how your experience helped you better understand the concept, skill/technique, or tool – reference specific course material where applicable.
3. **Articulate Learning:** How will this experience (what you have learned) impact how you behave or approach ethical decision making? How might this learning transfer to different contexts (e.g., online vs. in person) or workplaces?

Prompt B

B: Describe how you deliberately sought to practice (or observe) what you learned in this course in a concrete experience this term. What did you (or someone else) intend to achieve? What actually happened? For example, maybe you tried to challenge your zero-sum thinking or paid more attention to

how much you allow your private morality to influence the decisions you make. Perhaps you've been focusing on acting outside of self-interest or ensuring the decisions you made/make are justified.

1. **Describe:** Describe the instance in which you deliberately practiced or observed something related to the course. Describe both the intention and what happened.
2. **Examine:** How was the outcome different or similar to the intention? Why was there a difference between intent and outcome? Was your practice attempt (or the attempt you observed) successful? Could it have been more successful? How did what happened impact your understanding of course content (reference specific course material where applicable)?
3. **Articulate Learning:** How will this experience impact how you act or approach situations in the future? How might this learning transfer to different contexts (e.g., online vs. in person) or workplaces?

Prompt C

C: Describe something in PD9 that surprised or challenged or unexpectedly intrigued you. Perhaps it was something that gave you insight into yourself or made sense of a situation you experienced or observed in the past. Perhaps it was something you had not thought of before that shed new light on the topic of the course or made you rethink something you thought you knew.

1. **Describe:** Describe something you learned in this course that particularly resonated with you in some way, expanded your understanding, and/or stretched your thinking. What was your reaction to what you learned?
2. **Examine:** Why do you think what you learned had the impact that it did? What questions do you still have?
3. **Articulate Learning:** How will this experience (what you learned) impact how you act or approach situations in the future? How might this learning transfer to different contexts (e.g., online vs. in person) or workplaces?

*WORD COUNT: Your answer should be between 300 and 500 words **total**.*

WHICH PROMPT ARE YOU ANSWERING (A, B, or C): B

INCLUDE YOUR ANSWER TO Q1 HERE:

Describe

During my co-op term, a manager from another department asked me to complete a task that wasn't part of my formal responsibilities. Although I wasn't obligated to take it on, I agreed because I wanted to maintain a positive relationship and avoid potentially being seen as uncooperative. As a junior employee, I hoped this would reflect well on me and demonstrate initiative. However, the task ended up consuming more time than expected, pulling my attention away from my core duties. It also unintentionally set a precedent that made it difficult to refuse future requests, gradually blurring the boundaries of my role.

Examine

Looking back, my decision to help was more about avoiding discomfort than fulfilling a professional obligation. This experience connects directly to the concept of private versus public morality, discussed in Unit 02 of the course. While private morality is shaped by personal emotions and relationships, public morality is rooted in the duties and expectations tied to one's role. In this case, I let my private concerns—such as maintaining a likable image—override the public expectations of my position. The situation also reflects the idea of a right vs. right dilemma: both helping and declining could be morally justifiable, but each choice upholds different values. By choosing to help, I preserved interpersonal harmony but compromised professional clarity and set unrealistic expectations.

Articulate Learning

This experience made me reconsider the importance of making decisions based on professional integrity rather than personal discomfort. If a similar situation arises in the future, I would first consult my direct manager to explain the request and ask whether supporting the task fits within my role and current workload. This would ensure transparency and help me make a more balanced and informed decision. I would also reflect on my motivations—am I agreeing out of genuine alignment with my role, or out of a fear of disapproval?

Question 2

We are typically most satisfied when we are doing work that we enjoy and/or feel is important or fulfilling in some way. Consider what you enjoy about your work (type of work, work environment, etc.). Describe how concepts you learned about in PD9 helped you better understand what you enjoy or find fulfilling in your work.

When answering, incorporate **at least three** of the prompts into your answer. Please separate each prompt into its own paragraph. Highlight the prompts you reference.

Note: You are **not** expected to use the DEAL format for this question. To clarify, this question is about what you enjoy in your work regardless of your skill, knowledge, or confidence while Q3 is about your knowledge and confidence regardless of your enjoyment.

- How might your emotional responses to ethical decision-making influence your career pathway?
- How might you feel about having to act in the best interest of an organization that would require you to set aside your personal convictions?
- How might your private morality influence the kind of workplace culture or environment you would feel most comfortable with, the type of work you tend to gravitate towards, or the decisions you make or expect from others?
- How has anything you learned in this course helped explain what you did or did not enjoy about your work experience this term (or previous experiences)?
- How might your personal convictions be essential to achieving the kinds of work goals you feel are important?
- How might what you learned this term help you positively impact the world? For example, consider how improved ethical decision-making skills might help you positively impact the wellbeing of people, the environment, or the economy. The Lesson section in Unit 8 on the UN's Sustainable Development Goals might help you make these connections.

WORD COUNT: Your answer should be between 300 and 500 words **total**.

INCLUDE YOUR ANSWER TO Q2 HERE:

One concept that stood out to me from PD9 was the distinction between private morality and workplace culture, and how the former shapes the type of environments where I feel most comfortable. I've realized that I'm naturally drawn to teams where open communication, mutual respect, and integrity are emphasized. In one of my past co-op terms, I worked in a very hierarchical environment where decisions were made behind closed doors and junior employees were expected to follow instructions without context. While the tasks themselves were manageable, I found it hard to stay motivated because I didn't feel a sense of trust or shared purpose. In contrast, when I worked on a smaller team that valued transparency and welcomed input regardless of role, I felt much more engaged. This connection helped me understand that my private morality—rooted in fairness and inclusivity—aligns best with collaborative, transparent cultures.

Another insight from the course that helped me reflect on my work preferences is the idea of having to act in the best interest of an organization at the expense of personal convictions. I

realized that I would struggle in a role where the organization's goals conflict with my ethical values, such as ignoring environmental concerns for profit or compromising employee wellbeing for efficiency. In one instance, I was asked to format promotional material that made exaggerated claims about a product's capabilities. While the task was minor, I felt uneasy contributing to something I believed could mislead clients. Although I didn't have the authority to change the messaging, that discomfort stuck with me. PD9 helped me identify that I value alignment between my work and my ethics, and that long-term satisfaction for me depends on working for organizations whose goals I can genuinely support.

Lastly, PD9 helped me see how emotional responses to ethical decision-making can influence my career pathway. I've often found myself paying close attention to how decisions are made—who is affected, whether trade-offs are acknowledged, and if values are consistently applied. These emotional reactions—whether frustration, pride, or discomfort—are not random. They're signals that ethics matter deeply to me and could play a central role in shaping my future. For example, I've started to explore roles in social impact, sustainability, and responsible tech because these areas align with my internal compass. Understanding my emotional responses has given me a clearer sense of direction and has helped me prioritize not just what I'm good at, but what feels meaningful.

Question 3

We also tend to feel more satisfied when we are doing work we are good at. Your future work will definitely require ethical decision making – perhaps a little, perhaps a lot. Describe how competent and confident you currently feel about your ethical decision-making skills and how you can build on what you have learned in this course.

When answering, integrate **all** of the following prompts into your answer. Each prompt should be addressed in its own paragraph.

It may be helpful to review the “University of Waterloo’s Future Ready Talent Framework (FRTF)” content from Unit 1 to see examples of how ethical decision-making skills covered in PD9 are related to career competencies.

Note: You are **not** expected to use the DEAL format for this question. To clarify, this question is about your knowledge and confidence regardless of your enjoyment while Q2 was about what you enjoyed regardless of skill, knowledge, or confidence.

- How knowledgeable or confident do you feel about your ability to make ethical decisions in contrast to when you first started this course, and how did taking this course impacted your sense of competence or feeling of confidence? Perhaps you underestimated or overestimated your original ability.
- How has any of your experiences this term (course, work, or other) highlighted gaps in your knowledge or skill related to ethical decision making?
- How could you practice and improve in an aspect of ethical decision making that you struggle with, or build on existing strengths, over the next term or so?

*WORD COUNT: Your answer should be between 300 and 500 words **total**.*

INCLUDE YOUR ANSWER TO Q3 HERE:

When I first began PD9, I thought I had a decent understanding of ethical decision-making, mostly based on intuition and a general sense of fairness. But I now realize I often approached decisions in the workplace without fully considering their broader impact. This was especially true early in my recent co-op term, when I prioritized completing a high volume of tasks quickly over ensuring their accuracy. At the time, I believed that productivity would demonstrate competence. However, this led to avoidable mistakes, and my manager had to spend extra time reviewing and fixing my work. As I reflected on this, I recognized that speed without precision compromised not just my credibility but also the team's efficiency. Through the lens of PD9, I now see that ethical decision-making isn't just about dramatic moral dilemmas—it's also about being responsible, thoughtful, and aware of how your work affects others.

This experience exposed a gap between my understanding of responsibility and how it actually plays out in professional settings. I wasn't intentionally cutting corners, but I failed to weigh the downstream impact of rushing through tasks. In terms of PD9 concepts, I overlooked the importance of public morality—what I owe to the organization and team in my role. Ethical decision-making includes understanding the trust others place in you to do work well the first time, especially when their time and decisions depend on it. My actions unintentionally created inefficiencies, and I had to adjust. Eventually, I changed my approach, prioritizing accuracy over speed. This shift significantly improved both the quality of my work and my working relationship with my manager.

To continue improving, I want to build on my growing strength in self-awareness and responsibility. Over the next term, I plan to be more deliberate in checking my work, especially when tasks affect others' workflows. I also want to develop better judgment about when to ask questions upfront, rather than making assumptions just to finish quickly. One way I can practice this is by taking a pause before starting new tasks to reflect on how best to approach them—not just efficiently, but ethically. Incorporating the tools from PD9, such as asking who is affected and what responsibilities I have in my role, will help me act more thoughtfully in day-to-day decisions.

PD9 helped me understand that ethical decision-making isn't confined to extreme cases—it's embedded in everyday choices about quality, communication, and accountability. I now feel more competent and confident in making decisions that reflect both my personal values and professional responsibilities. This growth will continue to shape how I approach work, relationships, and future leadership opportunities.